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high decibel campaigns and well-publicised and well-packaged 'Discovery of India' tours. Of the UPA's policies, the NREGS was the most well-publicised and well-acknowledged programmes followed by the farm loan waivers. But does it mean that this is the end of regional politics or opportunistic politics? Far from it. If one looks at the results in Uttar Pradesh, it can be seen that the BSP has improved its vote share and the BJP's loss has been the Congress's gain. The SP is not a spent force in Uttar Pradesh.

In Maharashtra, the MNS has been eating into the vote share of the Shiv Sena and it has probably ensured six to seven additional seats for the Congress. In West Bengal, it was Trinamool Congress, a regional party, which won and the Congress is far from revival in the state. In Kerala, the Left's vote share has remained intact, but the BJP's vote share came down and enabled the Congress to win. In these elections, one trend may have been that the electorate decided to go for the winnable candidate of its interest groups and was willing to change party affiliations. Regional parties which lost heavily in terms of number of seats are the Left Front, RJD and SP. And there were state-specific issues for their loss—most of which were encouragingly related to governance and law and order.

THAT EXTREME POLITICS, LEFT OR RIGHT, HAVE NO RELEVANCE IN INDIA IS WISHFUL THINKING, PLEASING AS IT MAY BE TO THE LIBERAL OBSERVER. STILL, THE BJP AND CPI(M) HAVE A LOT TO LEARN.

SUMEEET INDER SINGH



ANTI-INCUMBENCY IS NOT A GIVEN

More than the demise of regional politics, I believe the message that the Indian electorate has been giving for some time is that good governance matters and anti-incumbency is not a given. In one of CLSA's reports in January 2009, we had written, "The series of state elections in 2008 showed that anti-incumbency is not a given. It seems—miraculously at times—that incumbent governments win elections on the back of good performance and strong local leadership. If the trend persists, it will augur well for Indian democracy." Delhi, Gujarat, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Orissa and Chhattisgarh seem to be unequivocally giving this message. In Rae Bareilly in February, I met some BJP supporters who said they would vote for the Congress as the Rail Coach factory would generate jobs in the region.

Even in Bihar where Nitish Kumar is enjoying unprecedented approval ratings, the results could have been significantly different if Congress-RJD-LJP had fought the elections in a pre-poll alliance. In Andhra Pradesh, the Congress's vote share has remained the same even as it put up candidates in a large number of states. The difference was that the votes of the regional parties were